

Equatorial Guinea



Comprising the mainland territory of Río Muni and five islands on the west coast of central Africa, Equatorial Guinea, despite its name, lies just north of the equator.



GEOGRAPHY

The islands are mountainous and volcanic. The mainland is lower, with mangrove swamps along the coast.



CLIMATE

The island of Bioko is extremely wet and humid. The mainland is only marginally drier and cooler.



PEOPLE & SOCIETY

Equatorial Guinea is the only Spanish-speaking country in Africa. Río Muni is sparsely populated and most people there are Fang, an ethnic group also found in Cameroon and northern Gabon. Bioko is populated by Bubi and a minority of Creoles known as Fernandinos. Tensions between the two territories have been reignited by the discovery of oil off Bioko. Wealth is concentrated in the ruling clan; oil revenue in the last decade has made little impact on most people.



THE ECONOMY

Oil and gas now account for 97% of exports; the government has promised to reinvest the new funds in development. Timber, cocoa, coffee.



INSIGHT: In 2003, state radio declared President Obiang Nguema to be "like God in Heaven"



FACTFILE

OFFICIAL NAME: Republic of Equatorial Guinea

DATE OF FORMATION: 1968

CAPITAL: Malabo

POPULATION: 676,300

TOTAL AREA: 10,830 sq. miles
(28,051 sq. km)

DENSITY: 62 people per sq. mile

LANGUAGES: Spanish*, Fang, Bubi, French*

RELIGIONS: Roman Catholic 90%, other 10%

ETHNIC MIX: Fang 85%, other 11%, Bubi 4%

GOVERNMENT: Presidential system

CURRENCY: CFA franc = 100 centimes